



NIGHT VISION

The ancient Romans had a strange cure for people who couldn't see at night. They roasted a goat and rubbed fat from its liver onto the eyes of the patient, who also ate some of the liver. But it worked! Why? Because liver is rich in vitamin A, which helps you see in the dark.



SICK SCIENCE

Eating food rich in vitamin B12 cures a disease called pernicious anemia. In 1928, Dr. William Castle discovered that a protein made by the stomach helps the body absorb the vitamin. He tested this by giving anemia patients vitamin-rich food mixed with liquid strained from his own vomit! Sure enough, they got better more quickly.

DEADLY VITAMIN

Although vitamin A is vital to health, you can have too much of it. The livers of some animals contain so much vitamin A that they are dangerous to eat. The Arctic Inuit people have long known not to eat the livers of polar bears, seals, or husky dogs. However, several European explorers, desperate for food on long polar expeditions, found out the hard way when they became very ill after eating this meat.



FAST FACTS

- The best way to make sure you get enough vitamins is to eat a wide variety of foods, and not stick to just a few favorites.
- Vitamin C is a vital part of the human diet, but most other animals are able to make their own.
- Some common foods have vitamins added to make them more nutritious.
- Before they are born, babies need vitamins supplied by their mothers.

CRAZY CORN

In the early 1900s, a strange disease swept across the southern United States. Victims went mad and suffered sores on their skin. In 1915, Dr. Joseph Goldberger found that he could cause the symptoms by feeding people nothing but corn—a staple of the local diet—and cure them with a dose of yeast extract. He realized the disease was related to something missing from corn but found in yeast, later identified as vitamin B3.

